The chain of hands

DIAGRAM

1
Soldier
Carried a plaque out of the palace, following orders.

2
Officer
Led an expedition authorised in London.

3
Auction, London
Sold objects to pay for the expedition.

4
Dealer
Bought at auction. Lawful.

5
Museum
Bought from the dealer. Lawful.

6
Curator, 1950
Catalogued it. Took nothing.

Each was lawful where it took place. Each can point to someone earlier.

2022 · Smithsonian transfers ownership of 29 objects to Nigeria's NCMM

2023 · Oba of Benin declared owner; who holds them is disputed

The chain of hands (diagram) · Made for this exhibition